

The Cover Letter, Part by Part

A breakdown of a strong cover letter, with tips for writing your own. The quoted lines are a worked example.

The principle: a cover letter is not a summary of your CV. It answers two questions, why this firm and why you, using specific evidence rather than adjectives. Keep it to one page and three short moves: a sharp opening, proof of how you work, and a researched reason for choosing them.

1 Your Header and Their Address

"Muntasir Ali | 162-164 N Gower St | email | phone | LinkedIn L.E.K. Consulting, Nova South, 160 Victoria Street, London, SW1E 5LB"

TIPS

- Keep your own details to one tidy line beneath your name; a LinkedIn URL is expected.
- Always include the firm's full postal address block. It signals a tailored letter rather than a mass email.
- Add the date above the greeting. It is a small formal detail that many applicants forget.

2 The Salutation

"Dear Hiring Team,"

TIPS

- Address a named person whenever you can find one, for example "Dear Ms Lewthwaite,". It quietly proves you did the research.
- Match the sign-off to the greeting: a named person takes "Yours sincerely," while "Dear Hiring Team" or "Dear Sir or Madam" strictly takes "Yours faithfully,". This example pairs "Dear Hiring Team" with "Yours sincerely", which is the one thing to fix.

3 The Opening: Your Hook

"I am drawn to strategy consulting for a specific reason: the discipline of building conclusions from evidence rather than from assumption. That principle sits at the centre of how L.E.K. operates."

TIPS

- Name the role in the first sentence, then earn attention with a specific reason. Avoid generic openers such as "I have always been passionate about..."
- Anchor your motivation to something true about the firm. Here it is L.E.K.'s evidence-led approach, which shows you know who you are writing to.
- One idea per opening. The body does the proving, so resist listing everything at once.

4 The Signpost

"Three things from my first year demonstrate how I work:"

TIPS

- A signpost line tells the reader how the letter is structured, so they read with the right expectations.
- A clear number, such as "three things", makes the letter feel organised and easy to skim in seconds.

5 The Evidence: Your Three Bullets

"Structured problem-solving under pressure ... reduced the effective corporate tax rate from 25% to 12.5%, unlocking an estimated £400k to £1m ... Analytical decision-making with real stakes ... managed a \$20m portfolio to generate \$1.2m ... Building something from nothing ... grew to 350+ followers and 40+ members."

TIPS

- Lead each bullet with the skill in bold, then prove it with a specific, quantified result. Numbers turn claims into evidence.

- Vary the three skills so they cover different strengths, here technical, analytical, and entrepreneurial, rather than repeating one.
- Keep every figure consistent with your CV and across applications. Mismatched numbers undermine trust.

6 Why This Firm

"The firm's expansion of its Financial Services practice and its London-led Payments work address exactly the structural questions I find most interesting ... the London office ... a culture built around over 30 nationalities ... the local staffing model and early Associate ownership."

TIPS

- This is where most letters fail. Name specific practices, projects, or values you could only know by researching the firm.
- Connect each detail back to your own interests, so it reads as genuine fit rather than flattery.
- Avoid praise that could apply to any firm, such as "prestigious" or "market-leading". Specificity is the signal.

7 The Closing

"I would welcome the opportunity to demonstrate that in person on 9–10 June."

TIPS

- Close with quiet confidence and a forward look. Reference the specific interview or assessment date if you have one.
- One line is enough. Do not restate the whole letter.

8 The Sign-off

"Yours sincerely, Muntasir Ali"

TIPS

- Use "Yours sincerely" for a named recipient and "Yours faithfully" when you opened without a name.
- Add your title and degree beneath your name so the reader places you at a glance.